superpower of its time. About two centuries later the Persian model inspired Alexander's successful emulation. Starting from his small kingdom of Macedon near Athens he crushed revolts in several Greek cities before leading an expeditionary force that annexed kingdoms in Africa and Asia extending from Egypt to Persia, and eventually defeating eastern adversaries as far away as Punjab.[13]

Alexander died in his thirties and upon his death this vast empire, which at the best of times was difficult to effectively hold, quickly broke up into smaller realms. In Egypt the satrap appointed there by Alexander became the founder of a new dynasty. The fourteen kings of this dynasty, all bearing the name Ptolemy, ruled Egypt for almost three centuries. By the time of Ashoka's consecration the early Ptolemies had ensured that Egypt was the principal naval power of the eastern Mediterranean. In those parts of Asia which lay to the east and north-east of India, similar kinds of consolidation would soon commence. Some fifteen years after Ashoka's Kalinga march, King Zheng, later the first emperor of the Qin dynasty, came to power, and by 221 BC, after conquering rival states, presided over the unification of China around a centralized bureaucratic monarchy.[14]

Given all these conflicts and rivalries, it is hardly surprising that a considerable part of the history of the ancient world is of battles, wars, and conquest. Homer in about the eighth century BCE relating incidents around the conflict between the Greeks and the Trojans, and Herodotus in the fifth century BCE writing of the expanding Achaemenid empire, are probably the best-known chroniclers of ancient conquest, Homer more literary and Herodotus more gossipily historical. Why wars were thought necessary at all is a larger question which strikes one immediately and forcefully, but we dismiss it out of hand as foolish because of many of the things outlined in treatises such as the *Arthashastra*—that power must lie in the hands of powerful and capable men at the apex of armies, that the sustenance of dominion requires the expansion of power via these men and their armies